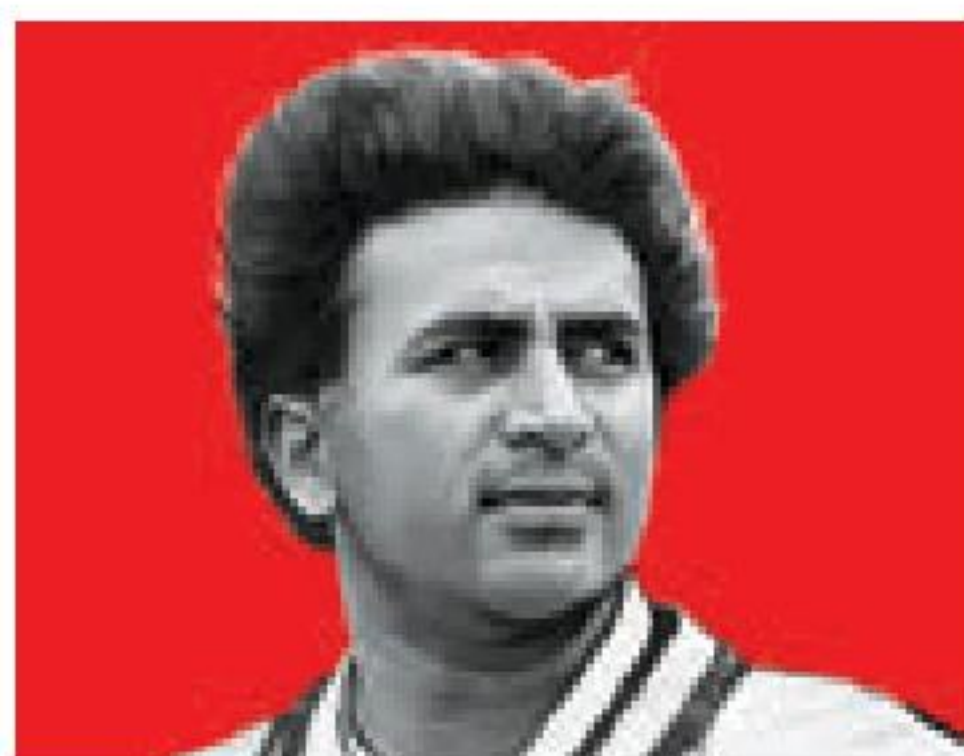




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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INDIA NEEDS TO UNDERSTAND THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A TEST AND A LIMITED-OVERS ALL-ROUNDER

Picking someone who cannot find a place simply as a batter or purely as a bowler may work in the short term, but it **does not add value** to the team.

Not for nothing are the South Africans the holders of the World Test Championship trophy. The way they have prepared for subcontinent tours is worth emulating. They went to Bangladesh and Sri Lanka earlier in the year and took a team that included spinners who could exploit the slow pitches of these parts. When they performed well and earned valuable points, the old-power media complained that they had not beaten top teams to reach the WTC final. This was rich, given that those very teams have failed to beat these so-called lesser opponents on several tours there. All that they have done is moan and whinge about the pitches and conditions every time they have lost.

Even for this Test match at the Eden Gardens, one of Ben Stokes's has-beens has got vocal about the pitch simply because 15 wickets fell on day two. I have been a has-been longer than this has-been, but I can say with conviction that the pitch was tough, not impossible to bat on. Temba Bavuma showed that with his short back-lift and soft hands, keeping his bat speed just slow enough so that even if the ball took the edge, it would not carry to the close-in fielder. He also showed admirable patience and great temperament, even when the ball went past the outside edge. In essence, it was proper Test match batting and not what modern batters do the moment they find it

is not a flat pitch and the ball is doing something off it. They think that going for the big shots will get them out of trouble. If anything, it gets them back in the pavilion. There are far too many who will tell them that there will be a delivery with their wicket on it, so better to go down trying to play big shots than fight it out with technique and temperament. They forget that red-ball behaviour differs from white-ball cricket, and that playing proper cricketing shots is the better option. They also overlook that Test cricket gives you the time to leave deliveries, unlike limited-overs cricket, where every ball counts.

By the way, when India toured Australia last year, 17 wickets fell on day one in Perth. In Adelaide, 11 fell on the first day and 14 on the second.

In Sydney, 11 wickets fell on day one and 15 on day two. Did the has-been have any complaints or caustic comments about those pitches? Absolutely not. Ten wickets on day two at Leeds. In Birmingham, eight wickets fell on the second, third and fourth days.

At The Oval, 15 wickets fell on the second day, but of course, unsurprisingly, not a word of criticism about the pitches in Australia and England. Lots of wickets fall in a day in Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, but nary a word of sarcasm. That is left for India and Indian pitches. So predictable this haranguing about Indian pitches and finding fault with everything about Indian cricket.